



Posted, Not Called

A Season-Long Taxonomy of Why a Suburban Vet Clinic’s Queue Board Misorders Its Own Patients

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Background

Every suburban vet clinic posts a paper queue board each morning — walk-ins and bookings, listed in arrival order. Reception routinely calls animals out of that order anyway. What decides who actually goes next, and does the pattern predict anything beyond itself?

Aims

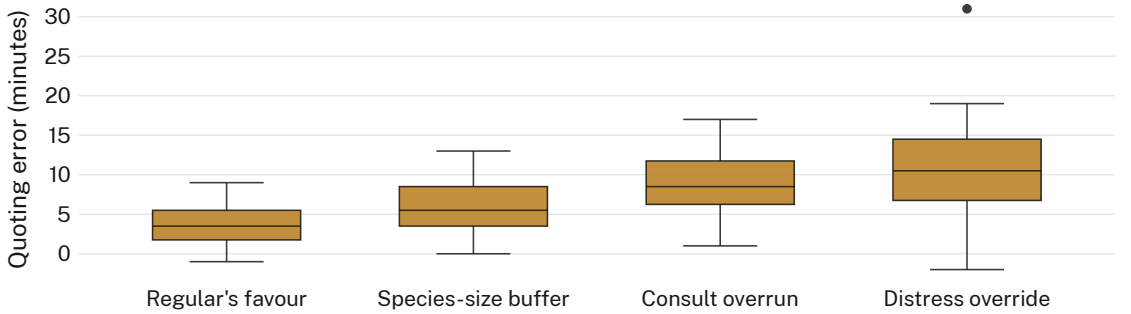
- Classify why the posted queue order and the actual call order diverge, into a taxonomy of causes
- Test whether cause category predicts the clinic’s own quoting error better than a raw divergence count
- Compare divergence composition and quoting error across six clinics over a season

Methods

- 6 suburban vet clinics · researcher-logged queue boards & check-in slips · 5-min call-order sampling · 11-week autumn season
- 346 queue events hand-coded into a 4-category divergence taxonomy by two independent raters ($\kappa = 0.81$)
- Quoted wait recorded at check-in; actual call time logged independently; taxonomy held constant across sites

Results

Divergence events cluster into four recurring categories (right). The taxonomy explains quoting error markedly better than the raw divergence count alone ($R^2 = 0.34$ vs 0.11).



Quoting-error distribution by divergence cause, 6 clinics, 11-week autumn season (n = 346 queue events, March–May 2026). Distress overrides carry the widest spread and the largest median error, 11 minutes, and drive 44% of the season’s total quoting-error minutes despite accounting for only 22% of divergence events.

Discussion & conclusions

The board is a courtesy, not a mechanism — cause, not count, predicts who actually waits longer. Quoting from divergence rate alone under-corrects hardest for the category that costs the most. Next: test whether naming the categories to reception changes quoting accuracy at all.

References

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Animal ethics approval 2026/058; queue order observed, never altered.



“The board says who’s next. The desk decides who’s next.”

22% of queue events at six suburban clinics departed from the posted order across an 11-week autumn season.